How an engagement runs

A one-day board briefing and a year-long fractional role run the same arc, at different speeds.

Read the system	Name what's true	Set the direction	Lead the change	Leave it capable
Days to weeks	One session	1–2 weeks	Ongoing	Final 1–2 weeks

Every phase draws on the same base: 39 years across 20+ sectors, working at both ends of the problem. The outside judgement of non-executive and advisory roles, and the inside delivery of fractional and interim leadership. What changes phase to phase is which lens is doing the work.

01

Read the system

Before any recommendation, the real constraints need to be visible: not the org chart, but how decisions actually get made and what's already been tried. Stakeholder conversations across the business, technology and the board, a review of existing strategy, and a diagnostic that maps dependencies rather than assuming them.

02

Name what's true

The findings go to the board or founder directly, including the parts that are uncomfortable. No softened language, no burying the real risk in a longer list of minor ones. The evidence is structured into the few things that actually matter, and put in front of the people who need to hear them.

03

Set the direction

Direction only means something once it has been tested against what the organisation can actually deliver. The assessment becomes a plan: priorities in order, resourcing made explicit, and a sequence built on real capacity rather than an ideal timeline.

04

Lead the change

This is where most technology advice fails: the plan is handed over and the advisor leaves. Here the leadership continues, embedded in the organisation, making the calls, adjusting the plan as reality intervenes, and carrying accountability for the outcome rather than the recommendation.

05

Leave it capable

The engagement ends by design, not by attrition. Decisions, rationale and context are documented and handed back deliberately, so the work doesn't quietly need me again next year. This is what separates fractional leadership from consultancy dependency.

One conversation.

No obligation. The right fit matters more than the right brochure.

Book a call →

nc@neilcatton.com · www.neilcatton.com/services.html

01 Read the system

Understanding the organisation as it actually runs

Before any recommendation, the real constraints need to be visible: not the org chart, but how decisions actually get made, where authority sits, and what's already been tried. This phase is about listening long enough to see the system clearly, not confirming what's already assumed.

Key activities

- → Stakeholder conversations across business, technology and the board
- → Review of existing strategy, architecture and governance documents
- → Mapping of decision rights, dependencies and known constraints
- → Technical and operational due diligence where relevant
- → Synthesis of findings into a single, shared picture

Timeframe

Days to weeks, depending on engagement scope

Deliverables

- → Written findings summary
- → A single view of the system as it actually operates

Read the system
Days to weeks

Name what's true
One session

Set the direction
1–2 weeks

Lead the change
Ongoing

Leave it capable
Final 1–2 weeks

02 Name what's true

An honest assessment, stated plainly

The findings go to the board or founder directly, including the parts that are uncomfortable. No softened language, no burying the real risk in a longer list of minor ones. This is the phase most engagements shorten; it's the one that makes everything after it useful.

Key activities

- → Structuring findings into a clear, evidenced assessment
- → Naming the two or three things that matter most, not twenty
- → A direct conversation with the board, founder or sponsor
- → Agreeing what "true" means before moving to a plan

Timeframe

Typically a single session, once the diagnostic is complete

Deliverables

- → Board-ready assessment
- → A shared, agreed statement of the real problem



Read the system
Days to weeks

Name what's true
One session

Set the direction
1–2 weeks

Lead the change
Ongoing

Leave it capable
Final 1–2 weeks

03 Set the direction

A plan that's sequenced and resourced

Direction only means something once it's been tested against what the organisation can actually deliver. This phase turns the assessment into a plan: priorities in order, resourcing implications made explicit, and a sequence that reflects real capacity rather than an ideal timeline.

Key activities

- → Prioritising against impact, risk and delivery capacity
- → Building a phased roadmap with realistic sequencing
- → Identifying capability, resourcing and governance gaps
- → Testing the plan with the people who'll have to deliver it

Timeframe

One to two weeks

Deliverables

- → Sequenced roadmap
- → Resourcing and capability plan



Read the system
Days to weeks

Name what's true
One session

Set the direction
1–2 weeks

Lead the change
Ongoing

Leave it capable
Final 1–2 weeks

04 Lead the change

Embedded leadership, not a handover of slides

This is where most technology advice fails: the plan is handed over and the advisor leaves. Here, the leadership continues: embedded in the organisation, making the calls, adjusting the plan as reality intervenes, and carrying accountability for the outcome rather than the recommendation.

Key activities

- → Fractional or interim leadership of the delivery effort
- → Day-to-day decision-making within the agreed mandate
- → Regular reporting to the board or sponsor
- → Course correction as the programme meets reality

Timeframe

Ongoing: weeks to months, set by the mandate

Deliverables

- → Delivery against the agreed roadmap
- → Regular, honest progress reporting

Read the system — Days to weeks

Name what's true — One session

Set the direction — 1–2 weeks

Lead the change — Ongoing

Leave it capable — Final 1–2 weeks

05 Leave it capable

A deliberate handover, on purpose

The engagement ends by design, not by attrition. Capability, decisions and context are handed back to the organisation deliberately, so the work doesn't quietly need me again next year. This is what separates fractional leadership from consultancy dependency.

Key activities

- → Documenting decisions, rationale and open risks
- → Transferring capability to the team taking over
- → Formal handover to the board or successor
- → Agreeing what "done" looks like before leaving

Timeframe

Final one to two weeks of the engagement

Deliverables

- → Documented handover pack
- → A capable team, not a dependency

Read the system
Days to weeks

Name what's true
One session

Set the direction
1–2 weeks

Lead the change
Ongoing

Leave it capable
Final 1–2 weeks

One conversation.

No obligation. The right fit matters more than the right brochure.

Book a call →

nc@neilcatton.com · www.neilcatton.com/services.html